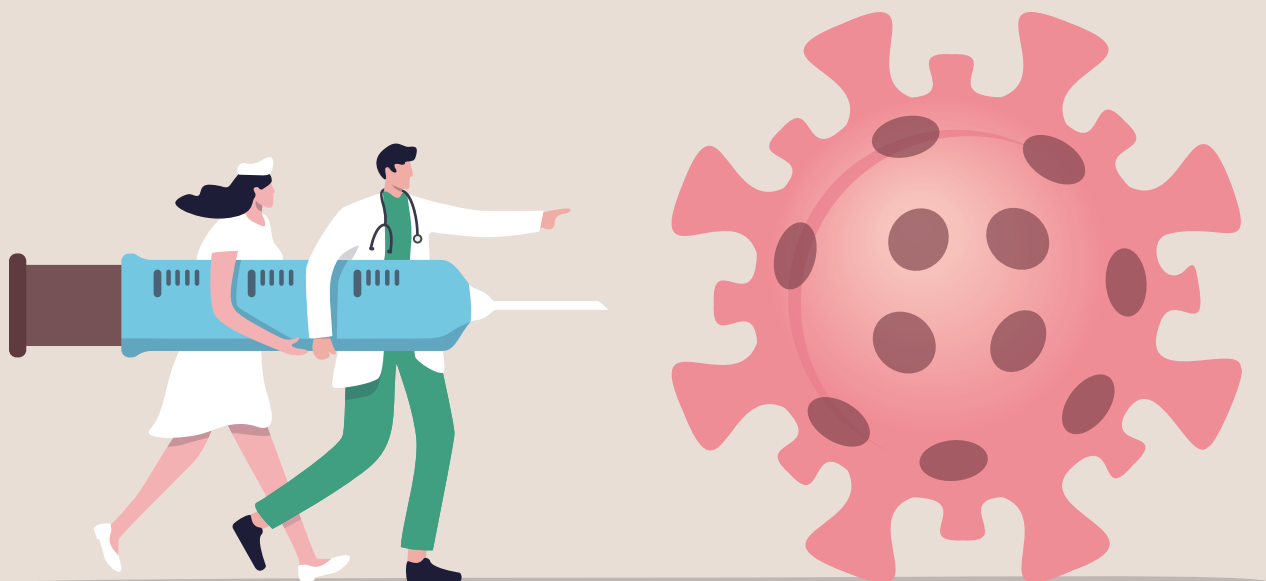




THE DRIVE TOWARDS A CURE

INDIA ACCELERATES RESEARCH AND INNOVATION
FOR COVID-19 TREATMENTS

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The novel coronavirus, that utterly transformed life the way we knew it, appeared first in India on January 30 in Kerala.

Merely a handful of cases were discovered across India during January and February. Unfortunately though, this dry spell didn't last long. By mid-March, the cases began burgeoning in several states, especially as more testing kits became available. The pandemic's alarming virality was finally being seen in India and on March 24, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced a complete nationwide lockdown for 21 days. According to reports, the growth rate of the pandemic did manage to slow down by April 6 with the infections doubling every six days instead of doubling every three days before the lockdown. However, this relief was temporary, and daily new cases began picking by mid April.

The lockdown was extended yet again on April 14 until May 3 with a

conditional relaxation from April 20. While the nationwide lockdown is a stellar move implemented to curb the rapid spread of the virus and relax the stress on our healthcare system, India's \$2.9 trillion economy has almost completely shut down with the lockdown being implemented. At the time of writing this article, the infections have reached a total of 31,332

cases across the country. These numbers could be conservative since testing is still scarce in relation to the population of the country, and the infected could be asymptomatic. In fact, Dr Raman R Gangakhedkar of the ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research) stated that about 80 per cent of India's COVID-19 cases were asymptomatic! Therefore, the drive



Empty street in Pune, India during the nationwide lockdown

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